female Buddhas, Queen Srimala embarked on the bodhisattva path, and gained the ‘lion’s roar’ or eloquence of an enlightened being. Scholars have noted striking similarities between the textual style of Srimala, aspiring to nirvana, and Chamtisiri doing the same in her inscriptions. The Srimala text may well have been influenced by Chamtisiri herself, or written to honour her.

At its peak, the population of Vijayapuri was likely in the tens of thousands. The ASI found only thirty-odd monasteries, each with ten to fifteen cells on average, yet estimated that the Buddhist monastic community numbered 4000, which seems high. Even with two monks to a cell and some guest monks, 1000 monks seem like a better estimate. Scholars Sukumar Dutt and H. Sarkar, and art historian Elizabeth R. Stone, see Vijayapuri marking ‘a transition from Hinayana to Mahayana’, concluding that its Buddhist art and architecture, ‘while clearly Hinayana Buddhist in origin, was built by Hinayanists who were taking the path to the Mahayana, with monks gradually acceding to both stupa and image worship’ and adding Buddha shrines in their monasteries.[28] A key figure in the rise of Mahayana Buddhism was Acharya Nagarjuna himself.

What Nagarjuna Said

The name ‘Nagarjunakonda’ first appears in medieval inscriptions, such as of Vijayanagar, suggesting a long memory of its association with Nagarjuna, a monk-philosopher and founder of the ‘Middle Path’ school of Mahayana Buddhism. He likely served the cause of Buddhism under the Satavahanas but is also said to have been a citizen of Vijayapuri in the third century CE. These claims are based not on hard evidence but inferred from early Tibetan texts, written centuries later. Most likely, Nagarjuna was in Amravathi but in middle age, towards the end of the Satavahana rule, he migrated to Sriparvata, an early name for Vijayapuri. He lived and taught there in a monastery until his death; the monastery was then perhaps named after him. This also fits circumstantial evidence related to Nagarjuna’s foundational role in the development of Mahayana Buddhism, which substantially happened at Vijayapuri.